

Who's making money off your data?

Here are some of the businesses that are getting rich off of your need to Like, Poke and Share

time when Mark Zuckerberg was just getting his brainwave – but was quite simply way ahead of its time. Facebook, on the other hand, opened to the public and shot to stardom because it came at a time when all of us net junkies were just getting over our need to be anonymous online. Thanks to the blogging culture and sites such as YouTube making us famous, people realised the value of being “real” online. So when this site came along that required you to be yourself, and network, primarily, with people you already know, it was obviously well received.

The real you

Now we get to the reason for that rather long (and perhaps, seemingly pointless) introduction. The “real you” is what advertisers, businesses, spammers, and almost anyone running a net business are interested in. Before Facebook, many of us used disposable email addresses to register at sites – services such as mailinator.com helped – because spam was to be avoided at all costs. All of those email addresses were of no real use to businesses that wanted to bombard you with ads and offers. Plus, even if you did provide your email address, your spam filter would take care of such mails anyway – much like it does now.

Imagine the parties that were thrown at online business houses when we changed the very way we conducted ourselves online – instead of guarding our data like paranoid conspiracy theorists, we started posting it all online ourselves!

Thanks to Facebook, and the popularisation of apps, much more about you is now known to those who have an interest in you. Now we're not suggesting that you're being exploited worse than a slave in the wild west. Quite the contrary, you actually enjoy all the freebies thrown at you by such companies, and letting them know which school you went to, where your last holiday was or which restaurant you just

“checked into” really doesn't bother you as much as it used to. We assume that last bit of course, because the data suggests so.

That said, let's look at some of the businesses who make considerable money off you and your personal data:

Zynga

Everyone who has a Facebook account would have heard of *CityVille*, *FarmVille*, *Mafia Wars*, and other Zynga games. Although it isn't the only way to play some Zynga games, many of the popular ones are tied solely to Facebook.

Zynga is famous for making simple and addictive games that make you spend hours a day on them. From personal experience we can tell you that FarmVille is our most hated / loved,



The Wisdom Control Panel. Making sense of your friends' data

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